

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 4

Resisting with Joy ~ Forgiveness

3 May 2026



"Inner Mongolian Child" Photographed by Han Chengli

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on LAUDA ANIMA and BROTHER JAMES AIR

May the Third be with you (Selections from Star Wars, adapted for Organ by C. Bull):

- A New Home / Cantina Band (John Williams)
- Duel of the Fates (John Williams)
- Princess Leia's Theme (John Williams)
- May The Force Be With You (John Williams)
- The Mandalorian (Ludwig Göransson)
- Your Father Would Be Proud (Michael Giacchino)
- Yoda's Theme (John Williams) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Doug Hart & Rev. Lehman

The sacred stillness of early morning,
a quiet moment in the sun,
small children laughing on scooters,
trees bursting with bloom and surprise lilies suddenly appearing.
These small joys reveal the truth of the world in which we live.

No, there is not peace everywhere
and there is so much pain all around.
Yet there are still people settled at home,
voices that sing and pray,
moments of forgiveness,
and songs of hope.
*We don't have to wait until all is well
to celebrate the glimpses of your Joyful Dream unfolding.*

On this day, with this gathered community,
let us not deny sadness,
but transform it into fertile soil for more joy.
*Let us not deny the gloom,
but choose to live in the light,
in all the days to come.*

- Inspired by Henry Nouwen's, *The Return of the Prodigal Son*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Praise with Joy the World's Creator

LAUDA ANIMA

Praise with joy the world's creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise the Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upends religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride,
Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide.
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in Community.
Calling people to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

Prayer of Awareness

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, in this sacred place,
we claim that we are creatures made in your image,
and that you have given to us
elements of your divine creative power:
the power of the Word made Flesh,
the power to speak hope into our earthly reality.

This morning, as together we form these words,
let us speak them for ourselves, and for all people,
that we might find a way
to weave them into your dream,
as we seek to create heaven on earth.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Sheep May Safely Graze"
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

***The Lord's Prayer**

Doug Hart

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.*

*Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

There is such joy in finding the peace that comes when we forgive
and we have been forgiven.
This morning, we are challenged to think about forgiveness in new ways
that ask us to accept reality and move to the beauty of the peace that comes
when we truly believe we are all the beloved of God.

This morning, as we share the ancient words of our liturgy,
and let them sink into our being,
we pray for our hearts to open to all that can be.

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Rev. Lehman & Doug Hart

from the Gospel of John, chapter 21

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, we gather in this place looking for your way.
We have left old paths to find new directions
and discover new stories,
as we dare to explore the horizons,
that are before us.

We are surprised that on the way, life meets us,
hungry for justice, for bread and for peace -
It calls us to see, to hear and to act,
finding new words born of the courage to speak.

In our joining together may we find strength
to serve:
the least and the little,
the unseen, the neglected,
the lost and rejected,
and the courage to overcome
the fear of the cost.

On this day, we celebrate this way that we travel,
we celebrate the joy of experience,
the love we share,
and the peace...that never lets us rest.

*And in all of this we say thank you –
for the way that stretches before us,
for the way that lies behind us,
and for the way that we will make together...
we hope with thankful hearts.
Amen and Amen!*

Meditation Anthem

"In manus tuas"
Laude

JOHN SHEPPARD

*"Into your hands, O God, I commend my spirit.
You have redeemed me, O God of truth."*

Sermon

Forgiveness ~ Freeing Ourselves from the Past

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Doug Hart

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Ima Kokino"
Cathedral Choir

KO MATSUSHITA

*"Now I'm here. Now I'm here, I sing. Now I'm here, I stand. Now I'm here, I listen.
Air, wind, and light flow through my body. Air, wind and light overflow from my heart.
Now I'm here, now and here I sing. Now and here, I stand. Now and here, I listen.
The song flows through my body to you. The song, from you, flows through my body." ~Ito Reiko*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Doug Hart

Holy One, we offer this prayer of gratitude
for all that is sacred in our lives.
You, who needs no words, remind us
that we need words to open our hearts
and our minds.
Help us to sense
our inner strength,
our inner purpose,
our inner joy,
our capacity to love.
*As we offer our gifts to you,
let us remember that all good things come from you.
Teach us in the days ahead to love each other
as we love you.*
May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

To the home of peace,
to the field of love,
to where forgiveness and right relationship meet
we look, O God, with longings for the earth's children,
with compassion for the creatures,
with hearts breaking for nations and the people we love.

*Open us to visions we have never known,
strengthen us for self-givings we have never made,
delight us with a oneness we could never have imagined,
that we may truly be born of you,
makers of peace, reservoirs of joy.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Eye For Eye"
Cathedral Choir

SHAWN KIRCHNER

*Hymn for the Journey

God is My Shepherd

BROTHER JAMES AIR

God is my shepherd, I'll not want, I feed in pastures green.
God grants me rest and bids me drink from waters calm and clean.
Through daily tasks, I'm blessed and led by One I have not seen.

Restored to life each morning new, I rise up from the dust
To follow God whose presence gives me confidence and trust.
I praise the name of God today; in God I put my trust.

When I must pass through shadowed vale, where loss and death await,
I will not fear for God is there, my shepherd strong and great,
Whose rod and staff will comfort me and all my fears abate.

No enemy can overcome, no power on earth defeat
The ones anointed by God's grace and fed with manna sweet.
My cup is filled and overflows as I my savior greet.

Goodness and mercy all my days will surely follow me;
And where God reigns in heaven and earth, my dwelling place will be.
My shepherd blesses, cares, and leads through all eternity.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

The Throne Room and End Title from *Star Wars* (John Williams, arr. C. Bull)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"In the month of May we celebrate AAPI cultures and histories in all of their vastness. With delight, we are singing Japanese composer Ko Matsushita's "Ima Kokino" today. Matsushita is one of those rare figures in the arts that has established a dynasty through the generosity of his spirit and his apparent love of the medium. His impact on choral music in Japan, and by extension on the world, is unique and robust. In 2014 the "Sing for Japan" concert came into being to raise awareness and money for victims of the Great East Japan Earthquake in 2011. Matsushita wrote "Ima Kokino" for this event, set to words by his friend, the poet Ito Reiko. One comment I read online said that "When people sing the song, they can feel air, wind and light, while cherishing the pure meaning of friendship and life." The piece is a full life celebration that anchors deeply into the earth, giving us freedom for us to dance in the breeze. I programmed it for today because I feel like it aligns with the way I feel when I release into forgiveness. Forgiveness is a way of remembering. When we forgive, even if we are forgiving someone else, we are actually letting ourselves set down all of the torpor and consternation that have come with whatever we have kept unforgiven in our bodies. A forgiveness moment begins with the past and becomes a moment here and now, an expression of the present. Reiko's text allows us to reflect on the past, on those who suffered through a natural disaster and the pain it left with them and us by realizing that we are here in this moment. We feel the air, we recognize our relationship to the earth, and we hear music flowing from us to others and from others to us. Our blockades are lowered. We are free to receive and to give, just like when we exist in a state of forgiveness. Matsushita's music gives Reiko's poem a brain-body connection through repetition. He builds the piece on a simple choral. Every time he repeats the chorale, he adds slightly different rhythmic, timbral, and textural elements such that we hear again the central refrain of "I'm here," but in new contexts. As a mirror to memory, the music gives our brains something

to return to. Each time we return, we are met with newness and depth. In a particularly poignant moment, he ends the piece with a stunning harmonic choice. He chooses to repeat the line “I sing” at the very end. The piece is in D flat, and he leads the harmony to D flat, having the sopranos and tenors fulfill that motion and sustain a D flat. The altos and basses, however, sing a D major chord for two whole bars. This turns the D flat from being the core sonority into a dissonant seventh. The moment actually feels sweet in our ears. Metaphorically, he has given us music that holds place for forgiveness. The tensions of the past melt into a new reality before resolving on the final chord. John Sheppard, the 16th century English composer, wrote some of the world’s most beautiful music. His pieces often relate to letting go of our need to control. He lived through a devastating pandemic, the upheaval of political order, and the growth of a holy war that directly impacted his livelihood and safety. His music reveals that he found ways to forgive the world and himself within it by releasing his spirit into the divine. The text for “In manus tuas” often appears with funerary rites. This week it felt more apt for the living. As we learn to relate to parts of ourselves that have kept us captive to past experiences and beliefs, we find forgiveness. We end the day with Shawn Kirchner’s “Eye For Eye.” Set to Mahatma Gandhi’s immortal words, and written in Shawn’s folk-classical style, it reminds us that forgiveness represents our only real path to peace for ourselves and in community. To develop strong forgiveness tools we have to start with ourselves. When we can feel the release of the voices that haunt us, and compassionately relate to all of the pieces that make us complex and human, then we can begin to feel the calm and trust that the composers for today built their music upon.